Resolve for the Future: Levi's Fidelity, Benjamin's Shoulders, and the Second Tablets

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The Daily Learning Portions

- **Chumash:** Parshat Vezot Haberacha, 2nd aliyah — Devarim 33:8–33:12
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 55–59
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, middle of Epistle 20
- **Rambam (3 ch.):** Hilchot Kelim 6–8
- **Rambam (1 ch.):** Hilchot Ishut 25
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Positive Commandment 108 — the purifying waters of the Red Heifer (*mei niddah*)
- **Hayom Yom:** Tishrei 10, Yom Kippur — liturgical order of the day (Kol Nidrei through Ne'ilah); *Or zarua* once, aloud; *Al daat hakahal* three times, softly; Thirteen Attributes even on Shabbat; extra Tehillim by stations; Ark open from *Ashrei* of Ne'ilah through the end; *Hayom yifneh* even after dark; *She'asah li kol tzorki* not said until the morning after Yom Kippur; the fast is twenty-six hours
- **Seasonal overlay (not a replacement of the daily cycle):** Five services: Maariv/Kol Nidrei (Sunday evening, 20 September 2026), Shacharit, Musaf (Seder HaAvodah), Minchah (Jonah), Ne'ilah. *Al Chet* ten times. Yizkor after the morning Torah reading. Festival leining: Vayikra 16 / Bamidbar 29:7–11 / Yeshayahu 57:14–58:14; Minchah: Vayikra 18 / Yonah / Michah 7:18–20. Baal Shem Tov extra Tehillim completed today: 115–123 before Kol Nidrei; 124–132 before sleep; 133–141 after Musaf; 142–150 after Ne'ilah. White garment. Five afflictions. No *tachanun* through Tishrei. Kiddush Levanah of Tishrei customarily after nightfall at the end of the fast. Begin the sukkah after the fast.

Seasonal frame. On Erev Yom Kippur, 20 September 2026, the hinge was named. Hayom Yom placed the two days on one axis: Erev Yom Kippur is *charatah* on the past; Yom Kippur is *kabbalah* for the future. Remorse without resolve is unfinished. Resolve that skipped remorse would have been unrooted. The hinge has already turned. Today the work is not to reopen the year as a brief. Today the work is to take one future and bind it.

This is also the calendar's own origin-story for the day. Eighty-two days after the Calf, after two stretches of forty on the mountain, the Holy One restored His goodwill "gladly and wholeheartedly," said to Moses *salachti kidvarecha*, and gave the Second Tablets. The day of atonement is not an invention of later liturgy. It is the day a broken covenant was rewritten in stone and placed again in human hands. A people can shatter what it received and still be given what it cannot earn.

Elul trained a meeting in the Field. Rosh Hashanah seated the King. The Ten Days were the nearness of which Isaiah spoke. Today that nearness is concentrated into five services, a white garment, a closed mouth, and an Ark that stays open from *Ashrei* of Ne'ilah until the last word. The Field is not cancelled. It is gathered into the Holy of Holies that no living kohen now enters, and into the heart that still can.

The second aliyah of the last parsha is not accidental company for that gathering. Moses blesses Levi and Benjamin. Levi is the tribe that would not spare its own when the word required it, and is therefore fit to teach ordinances and to place incense. Benjamin is the beloved who dwells securely, covered all day, with the Presence between his shoulders — the Temple in his portion. On the day the High Priest once walked between those shoulders, the daily cycle names the tribe that carried the House and the tribe that served it.

I. The Second Aliyah: Levi's Cost, Levi's Teaching, Benjamin's Shoulders

> *"And of Levi he said: Your Tummim and Your Urim belong to Your pious man, whom You tested at Massah and whom You tried at the waters of Meribah." (Devarim 33:8)*

Rashi: the address is to the Shechinah. The Tummim and Urim were given to the man of Your *chasidut*. Levi did not join the complaint at the water. Another reading, from Sifrei: they were tried, and the accusation against them was false.

The blessing does not open with honor. It opens with a test. Massah and Meribah are not Levi's scandal; they are Levi's proof. A priesthood that has never been tried is an office, not a fidelity. Yom Kippur is the annual public memory that office without fidelity cannot enter the innermost room. The kohen gadol who walked in with the incense walked in as a man who could die there. Limited power under higher law is not a modern slogan laid on the verse. It is the condition of the vestments.

> *"Who said of his father and his mother, I have not seen him; neither did he recognize his brothers, nor did he know his children; for they observed Your word and kept Your covenant." (33:9)*

Rashi, Sifrei: at the Calf, Levi gathered to Moses and struck even maternal kin who were not of the tribe, because the word required it. They kept "you shall have no other gods." They kept the covenant of circumcision when a generation born in the wilderness had not.

The sentence is severe and must not be sentimentalized. Family is not cancelled by Torah. Family is placed under Torah. A chinuch that teaches children to despise father and mother has misread the verse. A chinuch that teaches children that blood outranks the word has misread it the other way. Levi's *hesed* is not softness. It is the capacity to see the person in front of you and still hear the command that is larger than the person. On Yom Kippur the confession is public precisely so that private loves cannot quietly rewrite the terms.

The covenant they kept includes circumcision — the mark placed on the body before the body can consent in speech. Yom Kippur returns to the body from the other side: five afflictions, a fast of twenty-six hours, a garment that resembles both angel and shroud. The body is not discarded. It is bound.

> *"They shall teach Your ordinances to Jacob and Your Torah to Israel; they shall place incense before You and whole-offerings upon Your altar." (33:10)*

Teaching and offering are one office. Levi does not keep the ordinances as a guild secret. *Yoru mishpatecha leYaakov.* The tribe that struck at the Calf is the tribe that must now explain the law to the people who were spared. Zikui ha-rabbim is not an extra piety added to priesthood. It is the priesthood. Incense and *olah* without teaching would be theater. Teaching without the altar would be a lecture. Yom Kippur holds both in one Musaf: the Seder HaAvodah recites the offering; the *Al Chet* teaches a people how to name what the offering once carried.

Rashi notes that *kalil* is the *olah*, consumed entirely. Nothing of it returns to the priest's plate. The day that seals the year is built on a gift that does not come back as property. Resolve for the future has the same grammar. A *kabbalah* kept as a private decoration is not yet an offering.

> *"Bless, O Lord, his army, and favor the work of his hands; smash the loins of those who rise against him, and his enemies, that they rise not again." (33:11)*

Rashi gathers two readings: contestants for the priesthood, and a prophetic prayer for the Hasmoneans — few against many. The blessing does not pretend that fidelity is unopposed. It asks that the work of the hands be received, and that those who rise against the work not recover. Yom Kippur is not pacifism of the soul. It is the request that what has been judged not stand up again as the same life. *Al yakumu.*

> *"Of Benjamin he said: The beloved of the Lord shall dwell securely beside Him; He covers him all the day, and between his shoulders He dwells." (33:12)*

Rashi: Benjamin is set next to Levi because the Temple was built in Benjamin's portion, dearer than the Mishkan at Shiloh in Joseph's. "All the day" — forever, once Jerusalem was chosen. "Between his shoulders" — the House sits slightly below the highest ridge, as shoulders sit below the head; the site was lowered from Eitam because a Sanctuary should rest as a burden is carried, not as a crown is seized.

On Yom Kippur the verse is almost too exact. The Presence dwells between the shoulders of a tribe, not in a man's private vision. The beloved dwells securely *beside* Him, covered all day. Covering is not disappearance. It is protection that still leaves a people standing. The kohen gadol who entered the innermost chamber entered on behalf of a nation whose House sat on Benjamin's ridge. The chamber is gone. The shoulders are not. A Jew who fasts in a rented hall in a city that is not Jerusalem is still, by the verse, under that covering.

The Elul image of the King in the Field and the Tishrei image of the King on the throne meet here without strain. A field is open approach. Shoulders are carried weight. Today the King is not strolling. Today the King is borne, and the one who bears is covered.

II. Traditional Approaches, Held Together

Sifrei / Rashi. Levi's praise is historical and legal: the Calf, the water, the Urim, the teaching, the altar. Benjamin's praise is geographic and eternal: the House in his portion, covered all day. The peshat does not require a sermon. It requires that the last parsha of the Torah still know which tribe may teach and which ridge may carry.

Ramban and Ibn Ezra. The blessings continue the paternal register that opened the parsha. Haazinu was witness. Vezot Haberacha is gift. Levi and Benjamin receive function, not flattery. Function on Yom Kippur is the only flattery the day will bear.

Chassidus, on the Second Tablets. The first tablets were the work of G-d and the writing of G-d, shattered at the foot of the mountain. The second were hewn by Moses and written by G-d. The Alter Rebbe and the later Rebbeim read the second tablets as the grammar of teshuvah itself: a human hand prepares the surface; the writing remains Divine. Yom Kippur is that collaboration made into a date. *Salachti kidvarecha* — I have forgiven, according to your word. The word of a man is admitted into the seal of Heaven.

Maharal / Nefesh HaChaim line. The Holy of Holies is the point at which space is concentrated until it can hold what space cannot hold. Benjamin's "between his shoulders" is not architecture only. It is the claim that a finite ridge can bear an infinite Guest. Tanya's lesson today will say the same in the language of *kav* and radiance.

Synthesis for the day. Levi is fidelity that costs. Benjamin is nearness that carries. The Second Tablets are a covenant that can be rewritten after rupture. Yom Kippur is all three at once: a people teaching itself its ordinances, carrying a Presence it cannot house as it once did, and receiving a writing it did not engrave. *Charatah* on the ninth named the rupture. *Kabbalah* today takes the second stone.

III. Tehillim 55–59: Evening, Betrayal, and the G-d Who Goes Before

The ordinary daily cycle gives five chapters that would have been enough even without the Baal Shem Tov's completion of the book.

Psalm 55: "Give ear, O G-d, to my prayer… Evening and morning and noon I complain and moan, and He hears my voice." A friend has lifted his heel. The speaker would flee to the wilderness. He does not. He casts his burden. Yom Kippur knows this psalm from the inside. The confession is not only about the sins a man committed alone. It is about the trusts he broke and the trusts broken against him. *Al Chet* has a social spine.

Psalm 56: "In G-d I have trusted; I will not fear. What can flesh do to me?" The fast reduces flesh to its proper size. Fear of flesh is one of the day's quieter idolatries.

Psalm 57: "Be gracious to me, O G-d, be gracious to me, for in You my soul takes refuge, and in the shadow of Your wings I will take refuge until destruction passes." Benjamin was covered all day. David, in the cave, asks for the same covering until the ruin has gone over.

Psalm 58: judgment on judges who judge unjustly. Limited power again, this time from the other side of the bench. A day of Heaven's court is also a warning to every human court.

Psalm 59: "O my Strength, to You I will sing, for G-d is my fortress." The last of the five does not end in analysis. It ends in a song that can be sung with a closed mouth.

Hayom Yom stations the rest of the book across the day's hinges: 115–123 before Kol Nidrei, 124–132 before sleep, 133–141 after Musaf, 142–150 after Ne'ilah. The entire Tehillim is completed on the day the gates close. That is not a reading plan. It is a claim: nothing of praise is left unsaid before the seal.

IV. Tanya, Middle of Epistle 20: Yesh from Ayin, Radiance of a Radiance

Today's Tanya continues the middle of Iggeret HaKodesh 20. The Alter Rebbe is explaining how created beings in Beriah, Yetzirah, and Asiyah come into existence as *yesh me-ayin* through the union of *za* and *nukva* of those worlds, drawing from the light of the *neshamah* in *malchut* of Atzilut, which already contains a radiance of the *kav* from Ein Sof. That radiance pierces the *parsa*. The *kav* itself, vested in Adam Kadmon, sends further radiances — a radiance, a radiance of a radiance, a radiance of a radiance of a radiance — into *neshamah*, *nefesh-ruach*, *kelim*, and all created beings. Ein Sof encompasses all worlds uniformly. Diversity and finitude appear only because the extension that animates them is graded.

The lesson is technical and it is the day's theology.

Yom Kippur can be misread as a flight from *yesh*. White garment, no food, no leather, no washing: it can look like a rehearsal for not being a body. The Alter Rebbe will not permit that reading. Creation is *yesh* from *ayin*, and the *yesh* is wanted. The Ein Sof that encompasses every world equally is not the whole story. If it were, there would be no day, no Temple, no shoulders, no fast. There is a *kav*. There is a piercing of a curtain. There is a diminishing that makes a particular soul in a particular year able to stand and confess.

Teshuvah, in this grammar, is not the destruction of the vessel. It is the vessel consenting to receive from higher than its own grade. The Second Tablets are a *kav* through a *parsa*: Divine writing on a surface a man has cut. Ne'ilah is the last hour in which a finite mouth asks to be animated from higher than it can hold.

The encompassing light does not need the fast. The extending light does. A republic of souls — if the phrase is used at all — lives in that distinction. Uniform encompassing would be empire. Graded extension, received by consent, is covenant.

V. Rambam and Sefer HaMitzvot: Vessels, a House's Terms, Water That Purifies and Defiles

Kelim 6–8. The three-chapter cycle stays inside vessels: how they receive impurity, how their form holds or fails, what counts as a receptacle and what does not. On Yom Kippur the tractate is almost loud. A person is a vessel. The day's five afflictions do not smash the vessel. They empty it enough that what it holds can be named. A vessel with a hole in the right place is still a vessel. A vessel that pretends it has no interior is not.

Ishut 25. The one-chapter cycle is still inside a house: vows the other party did not know, blemishes undisclosed, assumptions about what a spouse was entitled to learn from relatives or from the bathhouse, burdens of proof, later afflictions, trades that wound the life together. The chapter is legal and unsentimental. A union has terms. Terms that were hidden are grounds. Terms that arise later have their own law.

Yom Kippur is not a court of divorce. It is, however, the year's appointed hour for disclosure. *Vidui* is the refusal to keep from Heaven what a house would have to tell a partner. Non-domination, if the republican word is allowed, begins with not ruling another soul by concealment. A man who confesses what he has hidden has already stepped out of one kind of domination — the kind he practiced on the people who had to live with him.

Positive Commandment 108 — *mei niddah*. The ashes of the parah adumah mixed in water purify the one who is impure through a corpse, and the same waters defile the one who handles them. The paradox is the oldest in the purity system and it is the day's own image. Yom Kippur purifies. The one who carries the rite — once a kohen, now a people saying *Al Chet* ten times — does not come through untouched. Forgiveness is not a solvent that leaves the handler clean of labor. *Salachti kidvarecha* still required eighty-two days and two tablets and a man who cut the stone.

The parah adumah is also the rite that answers death. Yom Kippur answers a death of another kind: the death of a year, the death rehearsed by the kittel, the deaths named in Yizkor after the morning reading. Purification from contact with death is not denial of death. It is the Torah's insistence that death does not get the last word over a camp that still has to walk.

VI. Hayom Yom and the Order of the Day

Hayom Yom for 10 Tishrei is almost entirely an order of service. That is not a lesser teaching. It is the teaching. On the day of the seal the Rebbe records how a community stands:

- Kol Nidrei night begins *Hashem malach tageil*.
- *Or zarua latzaddik* is said once, and aloud.
- *Al daat hakahal* is said three times, softly.
- *Ki hinei kachomer* is not doubled.
- Bedtime Shema as on Shabbat and Yom Tov.
- *Avinu Malkeinu z'chor rachamecha* in every tefillah.
- Thirteen Attributes when the Torah is taken out, even if the day were Shabbat.
- Daily Tehillim after Musaf.
- Haftarah of Minchah: Jonah to *uv'heima rabbah*, then *Mi Kel kamocha*.
- *L'David Hashem ori* also at Minchah.
- Ark opened at *Ashrei* of Ne'ilah and left open until the service is finished.
- Kaddish of Ne'ilah: *l'eila ul'eila*. No *birkat kohanim*.
- *Hayom yifneh* even after dark.
- *She'asah li kol tzorki* is not said until the morning of 11 Tishrei.
- The fast is twenty-six hours.

Two details carry the theology. The Ark stays open. The blessing over ordinary provision is postponed. The gates are not yet closed while Ne'ilah is being said, even if the sky has already turned. And the body that has not been given shoes or food or water is not yet asked to thank for "all my needs." Needs will be named on 11 Tishrei. Today the need is one: *chatmeinu l'chayim*.

Hayom Yom of the ninth already assigned the interior work. The ninth: *charatah*. The tenth: *kabbalah*. The liturgical memorandum is how that resolve is given a body — five services, an open Ark, a book of Tehillim finished, a shofar at the end, a march sung in Chabad rooms as the fast breaks.

VII. Festival Overlay: Avodah, Jonah, Ne'ilah

The daily cycle is not replaced. It is accompanied.

Shacharit / Musaf. Vayikra 16 is the avodah: two goats, lots, a kohen who enters once, a people who wait outside, a confession over a living animal that will carry what the camp cannot keep. Bamidbar 29:7–11 is the day's additional offering. Yeshayahu 57:14–58:14 is the prophetic correction: loosen the fetters, share the bread, and do not call that a fast if the fist stays closed.

Minchah. Vayikra 18 binds the camp's holiness to the body's boundaries. Jonah is the reading a people on the tenth of Tishrei cannot avoid: a prophet who flees, a city that returns in sackcloth, a plant that dies, a question that is left open. *Mi Kel kamocha* from Micah closes the haftarah: iniquity is not kept forever; sins are cast into the depths of the sea. Tashlich was nine days ago. The depths are named again at Minchah because a seal still needs a sea.

Ne'ilah. The Ark is open. The gates of heaven are treated as closing. *Hayom yifneh* is said even after the day has already turned, because the service, not the clock, is the measure. A single long blast follows the last *Shema* and *Hashem Hu HaElokim*. In Chabad rooms Napoleon's March is sung. The joy is not a denial of the fast. It is the confidence Hayom Yom of the ninth already required: resolve for the future is allowed to be glad.

VIII. Practical Avodah

One focus, because the day will not hold ten.

Bind one future. Not a list. One *kabbalah* small enough to keep and large enough to cost. Levi's blessing is work of the hands that Heaven is asked to favor. A resolve with no hands is a speech.

Do it in this order, if the strength is there:

1. After Musaf, or in any quiet between services, write one sentence of resolve. Not a biography. A sentence.
2. At Minchah, hear Jonah as a warning against flight from the sentence you wrote.
3. At Ne'ilah, stand as if the Ark in front of you is the only door left open. Say the sentence inwardly before *Shema*.
4. After the blast and the drink of water, do not negotiate the sentence away over the table.
5. Before sleep, if the custom is kept, finish Tehillim 142–150. Let the book close with the last praise, not with the last anxiety.
6. On 11 Tishrei, before ordinary needs are blessed again, put one nail or one measurement toward a sukkah. The calendar does not leave a vacuum after the seal.

Family, if they are with you: a child does not need the whole Seder HaAvodah explained. A child needs to know that today we are quiet, white, hungry, and sure that we are covered. Benjamin dwells securely. That is enough chinuch for a fast.

If Yizkor is said: name the dead without using them as an escape from the living. Honor due to parents does not end at the grave and does not replace the *kabbalah* owed to the children still in the house.

IX. Chinuch Points for a House on Yom Kippur

- Moses blesses Levi for keeping the word when it cost. Ask, when the fast is over: what is one word we will not bargain?
- Benjamin carries the House on his shoulders. Ask: what do we carry that is not ours to own?
- The Second Tablets were cut by a man and written by G-d. A child can understand that a broken thing can be given again.
- Jonah ran. Nineveh returned. The book ends on a question. A house can live with a question if it will not live with a flight.
- The Ark stays open until the last word. So does a parent's door. That is not metaphor. It is policy.

X. Covenantal-Republican Resonance (only where the text already speaks)

Levi does not take a crown. Levi teaches ordinances and places incense. Priesthood here is limited office under a word it did not write. Benjamin does not seize the ridge. The Presence sits between shoulders that were lowered so the House would not perch like a trophy. Ishut 25 refuses a union built on concealment. Psalm 58 refuses judges who judge unjustly. The Second Tablets refuse both despair (the first stones are gone, therefore nothing can be written) and autocracy (the writing is Divine, therefore no human surface is required).

Non-domination is the name a later school gave to a life in which no one is arbitrarily at the mercy of another. The Torah's version is older and sharper: no one is ownerless, and no one is a god. Held in the hand, still bearing utterances. Covered all day, still standing. Forgiven according to a human word, still receiving a writing no human hand composed.

A people that can finish Tehillim, close a gate, blow one blast, and then build a sukkah is a people that knows how to live under law without being crushed by it. That is the civic lesson, if one is needed. It is not the day's center. The day's center is *salachti kidvarecha*.

Extended Bibliography

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G'mar chatimah tovah. The King is seated. The Ark is open until the last word. Resolve for the future. One sentence. Then the sukkah.

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